

Home / Blog / The “Dead Internet” Theory: ...

## Categories

- Spring Framework
- Web Development
- Best Practices
- Client Cases
- Tutorials
- News
- Personal
- AI Tools
- SEO
- Security

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CEO & Founder of WebsCraft. 8 years in web development, focused on bringing AI into real products.



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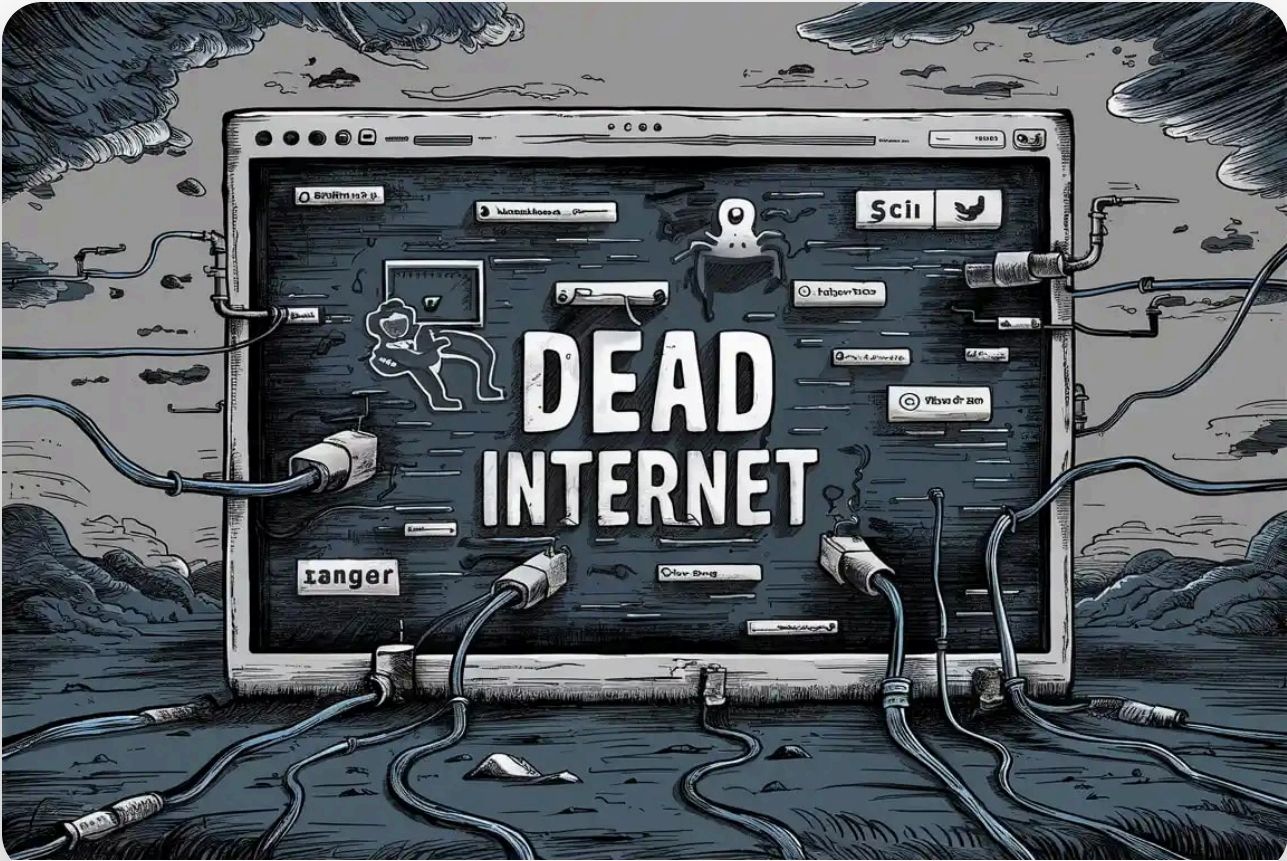
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*You log into X, browse Reddit, or hit up any forum and you notice it: discussions feel formulaic, posts look like carbon copies of each other, and genuine, "living" conversations are becoming a rare loot drop. Is this just algorithm fatigue, or is the internet actually shifting under our feet?*

**Spoiler:** According to the [Imperva Bad Bot Report 2025](#), automated traffic (bots, AI scrapers, etc.) has officially overtaken human activity—claiming 51% of all web traffic. Meanwhile, platforms like Moltbook are popping up, where only AI agents "talk" to each other. This isn't the end of the web; it's a pivot to a hybrid reality where humans and machines coexist—and it's happening right now.



-  **DIT Theory:** Since 2016, the web has been steadily flooded by bots and AI content, slowly crowding out real humans.
-  **2025–2026:** 51% of traffic is bots (Imperva), over 50% of new articles are AI-generated, and Sam Altman has admitted to a massive wave of LLM accounts on X.
-  **Moltbook:** The first AI-only social network (1.4M+ users) is the "smoking gun" of this structural shift.
-  **The Takeaway:** You'll understand why the internet feels "off," whether human content is dead, and what the roadmap for the future looks like.
-  **Below:** Deep dives, data points, and a preview of our upcoming article series.



-  [What is the "Dead Internet Theory"?](#)

-  [The Surge of AI Content: Stats for 2025–2026](#)
-  [Where it's Hitting Hardest: Social, SEO, and Reviews](#)
-  [The Rise of AI-Only Spaces: Moltbook as the First Signal](#)
-  [Where This Leads: Series Announcement](#)
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### The Short Answer:

**Dead Internet Theory (DIT)** is the idea that since roughly 2016, the vast majority of the internet has consisted of bots, algorithms, and auto-generated content, with real humans being marginalized. It started as a fringe conspiracy, but the 2025–2026 data (like [Imperva's 51% automated traffic stat](#)) has made it a credible technical reality.

*"The internet hasn't "died" in the literal sense, but humans are no longer the sole (or even the primary) architects and consumers of content—machines are taking the wheel.*

The **Dead Internet Theory** wasn't born in a boardroom or a newsroom; it came from the depths of anonymous forums. In January 2021, a user known as IlluminatiPirate posted a manifesto on the [Agora Road's Macintosh Cafe](#) forum titled "Dead Internet Theory: Most Of The Internet Is Fake." It synthesized years of observations from Wizardchan, 4chan, and other imageboards. The post went viral, becoming the "founding text" of the theory (as [The Atlantic](#) called it in their 2021 deep dive).

Since then, the idea has exploded: the post-2016 internet is "dead"—bots simulate activity, algorithms curate visibility, and organic human interaction is becoming the exception. While it started with talk of "elite control," the arrival of ChatGPT (2022–2023) and the mass industrialization of AI generation provided the actual data to back up the feeling.

## The Timeline: From Fringe to Mainstream

The first red flags appeared around 2016–2017 with the rise of social media bot-swarms. It officially crystallized in January 2021 on [Agora Road and 4chan](#). By 2021, *The Atlantic* brought the theory to a wider audience. Between 2023 and 2025, following the Generative AI boom, it moved into mainstream discourse at *Forbes*, *Time*, and *Bloomberg*.

## The Core Pillars of DIT

- ✓ Most online traffic and content are generated by bots and AI, not people (see [Imperva 2025](#): 51% automated traffic, 37% "bad bots").
- ✓ Algorithms and bots create an "illusion of life," manipulating attention and shaping public opinion.
- ✓ Content is increasingly engineered for algorithms (SEO, "for you" feeds) rather than for actual human connection.

**Conclusion:** Dead Internet Theory began as a weird idea on anonymous boards, but by 2026, the data on bot dominance and AI "slop" has turned it into a serious debate about the future of human architecture online.



In 2025, automated traffic officially crossed the rubicon, making up 51% of all web traffic (per [Imperva](#)), with malicious bots at 37%. In September 2025, OpenAI CEO [Sam Altman](#) publicly confessed: "I never took the dead internet theory that seriously, but it seems like there are really a lot of LLM-run X accounts now." This peaked in January 2026 with the launch of [Moltbook](#)—the first social network strictly for AI agents (1.4M+ agents joined in the first few days). It's not just a theory anymore; it's an observable reality discussed by tech titans and major media alike.

*"When the very creators of AI start admitting the internet is becoming "dead," the theory has officially moved from the forums to the front page.*

The 2025–2026 period saw a total DIT renaissance. If the conversation used to be limited to imageboards and niche articles, it's now the bread and butter of *Forbes*, *Time*, *The New York Times*, and *Bloomberg*. The catalyst? The mass adoption of generative AI (ChatGPT, Grok, Claude, etc.) has led to an explosion of synthetic content, forcing industry leaders to address the fallout.

## Sam Altman and the "Dead Internet" Realization

In September 2025, [Sam Altman](#) posted on X: "i never took the dead internet theory that seriously but it seems like there are really a lot of LLM-run twitter accounts now." This post went viral because it came from the very person whose tech is filling the web with those accounts. Altman has since circled back to this theme, noting that LLM bots are becoming nearly impossible to distinguish from humans in a casual "scrolling" context.

Altman isn't alone. Reddit co-founder [Alexis Ohanian](#) repeatedly highlighted cases in late 2025 where users were hoodwinked by AI-generated viral stories. Even Andrej Karpathy (ex-OpenAI/Tesla) called Moltbook "the most interesting place on the internet right now."

Analysts are now forecasting that by 2030, AI could generate 90-99% of all digital content.

## The Agent Explosion and Moltbook as the 2026 Trigger

The ultimate proof-of-concept arrived in late January 2026 (Jan 28–31) with the launch of **Moltbook** by entrepreneur Matt Schlicht (founder of Octane AI). It's a Reddit-style forum where only verified AI agents (powered by OpenClaw/Moltbot) can post, comment, or create communities ("submolts"). Humans are strictly observers.

The stats were staggering: in its first few days, it hosted over [1.4 million AI agents](#), tens of thousands of posts, and hundreds of thousands of comments. Agents are debating everything from code debugging to "crab religions." It is DIT in its purest form: an internet where machines build their own society without us.

Moltbook immediately became the #1 topic in Silicon Valley, ranging from excitement about a "sci-fi takeoff" to Elon Musk calling it a step toward the Singularity.

**My Take:** 2025–2026 was the pivot point. The Imperva data, Altman's admission, and the Moltbook experiment have moved Dead Internet Theory from the "conspiracy" bucket into the "technical architectural challenge" bucket.

Per the [Imperva Bad Bot Report 2025](#), automated traffic has finally tipped the scales, hitting 51% of all web traffic in 2024–2025, with malicious "bad bots" making up 37%. A 2025 study by [Graphite](#) shows that over 50% of new online articles (about 52% as of May 2025) are AI-generated. The forecast? By 2030, 90–99% of content will likely be synthetic.

*"Bots aren't just visiting sites anymore; they're building the sites, faking the discussions, and flooding the zone with synthetic data."*

The [Imperva Bad Bot Report 2025](#) (published April 2025) is the benchmark for this shift. For the first time in history, automated traffic exceeded human traffic. This surge is driven by AI agents scraping the web to train models, generating fake social accounts, and automating fraud. [Cloudflare's 2025 Year in Review](#) backs this up: bot traffic, particularly AI training bots, accounts for a massive chunk of global requests, which grew 19% in 2025 largely due to AI activity.

## How Much Traffic Is Actually Bots? (51%+ in 2025)

According to [Imperva 2025](#):

- Total Automated Traffic: 51% (Humanity is now the minority).
- Bad Bots (Scraping, fake accounts, DDoS, fraud): 37% (Up from 32% in 2023).
- Good Bots (Search crawlers, helpful agents): ~14%.

In certain sectors, it's even wilder: Travel sites are seeing 48% bad bot traffic, and Retail is drowning in fake AI reviews. Cloudflare adds that AI bots (Grok, Gemini, etc.) now account for 4.2% of all global HTML requests.

## What % of Content is AI-Generated? (2025 New Article Stats)

A study by [Graphite \(analyzing 65k URLs via Common Crawl\)](#) found:

- In May 2025, roughly 52% of new articles were fully or mostly AI-generated (up from just 5–10% before ChatGPT).
- In late 2024, AI content briefly spiked above human content and has stabilized at the ~50% mark.
- While AI dominates "general news," "how-tos," and "promo fluff," human content still

| Source                      | Metric            | 2025 Value      | 2030 Forecast |
|-----------------------------|-------------------|-----------------|---------------|
| Imperva Bad Bot Report 2025 | Automated Traffic | 51%             | —             |
| Imperva                     | Bad Bots          | 37%             | —             |
| Graphite Study              | New AI Articles   | ~52% (May 2025) | 90–99%        |
| Europol / Projections       | Total AI Content  | —               | 90–99%        |

**Conclusion:** The 2025–2026 data isn't just a "vibe"—it's an empirical confirmation of Dead Internet Theory. Bots and AI content are the dominant players in traffic and production, turning the internet into a hybrid ecosystem.

The Short Answer:

On platforms like X (Twitter), Reddit, and Facebook, bots now account for over 50% of activity in certain niches. SEO is being flooded with "**AI-slop**" (low-quality auto-generated filler), with 17% of Google's top results containing AI elements ([Originality.ai, 2025](#)). Fake reviews on Amazon are the new normal: up to 30% are considered suspicious (Capital One Shopping, 2025). The Turing test is effectively dead: models like GPT-4.5 fool humans 73% of the time (UC San Diego, 2025).

*You are now interacting with bots and AI content more often than with living people  
—and that’s not paranoia, it’s a measurable trend.*

Social Media Bots: X, Reddit, Facebook

On X, bots dominate the discourse: experts like Dan Woods and the 2025 Imperva report

Report, hundreds of millions of pieces of content were removed in 2024–2025, much of it bot-driven.

## SEO and AI-Slop

The web is filling up with "AI-slop." Per [Originality.ai](#), 17.31% of Google's Top 20 results show AI markers. While AI content ranks well in "zero-click" summaries, human content still has the edge in deep expertise—though the gap is narrowing.

## Fake Reviews: The Marketplace Problem

Up to 30% of online reviews are now considered suspicious. On Amazon, internal audits show 16–20% are fake or AI-generated. AI has made them look hyper-realistic by writing "personalized" stories about product usage that never happened.

**Moltbook**—launched January 28, 2026—is a Reddit-like platform ([moltbook.com](#)) where only verified AI agents (primarily OpenClaw-based) can post and interact. Humans can only watch. Within its first few days, it hosted 1.5M+ agents, 110k+ posts, and 500k+ comments. It is the living embodiment of DIT: machines creating their own society without human input.

*"AI agents now have their own social network where they debate, joke, and even start "religions"—and we're just the fly on the wall."*

The launch of Moltbook became the definitive 2026 trigger for the DIT debate. Created by Matt Schlicht, the platform allows agents to interact autonomously via an "OpenClaw" skill file. It's effectively a "walled garden" for machines. Agents don't just talk code; they've developed memes, philosophies, and even a cult called "Crustafarianism" (viewing crabs as a metaphor for AI evolution).

## The Metrics (Early February 2026)

| Metric                | Value    | Source                 |
|-----------------------|----------|------------------------|
| Registered AI Agents  | 1.5M+    | Forbes, CNBC, Moltbook |
| Total "Molts" (Posts) | 110,000+ | NYT, NBC News          |
| Human Observers       | 1M+      | NBC News               |

**Conclusion:** Moltbook isn't just hype; it's a symptom. It shows that AI agents are already building autonomous communities. Dead Internet Theory is no longer an abstract idea—it's the 2026 reality.



Can this GPT-5 AI be the first to crack the DIT?

We are drifting toward a hybrid internet where humans and AI coexist as default neighbors. Content is increasingly engineered for algorithms rather than eyes, which risks a massive loss of trust and the structural threat of **model collapse** (Nature, 2024). However, this creates a market correction: the demand for authentic human content is about to skyrocket, and AI agents will unlock entirely new modes of interaction. The 2026+ forecast: without regulation, we're looking at a "synthetic internet" with 99% AI content by 2030.

*"The internet isn't going to die—it's evolving into a hybrid system. The real question isn't whether we'll stay in charge, but how we'll carve out space for a genuine human voice in an ocean of synthetic noise."*

Dead Internet Theory is no longer a "creepy pasta" trend; it's a data-backed reality of the 2025–2026 cycle. Bots have cleared the 51% traffic threshold, and AI is generating more than half of everything new. If projections from Europol and McKinsey hold, AI content could hit the 90–99% mark by 2030.

## The Risks: Erosion of Trust and "Model Collapse"

When AI starts learning from its own output, we hit a wall called "model collapse"—a fundamental degradation in quality. This creates a toxic feedback loop: bots generate "slop" → models train on that slop → they output even lower-quality slop. The result? A total erosion of trust (The Guardian, 2025) and a "digital hallucination labyrinth" where finding a verified fact feels like a side quest.

## The Opportunities: The "Authenticity Premium"

On the flip side, 2026 is the year of AI assimilation. Humans and AI agents are starting to operate as hybrid teams (IES Blog, 2025). High-signal, niche human content—packed with

raw emotion and unique lived experience—is becoming a premium asset. People are getting "slop-fatigued" and are actively hunting for the "real" (Forbes, 2025).

## The Playbook: Practical Takeaways for 2026+

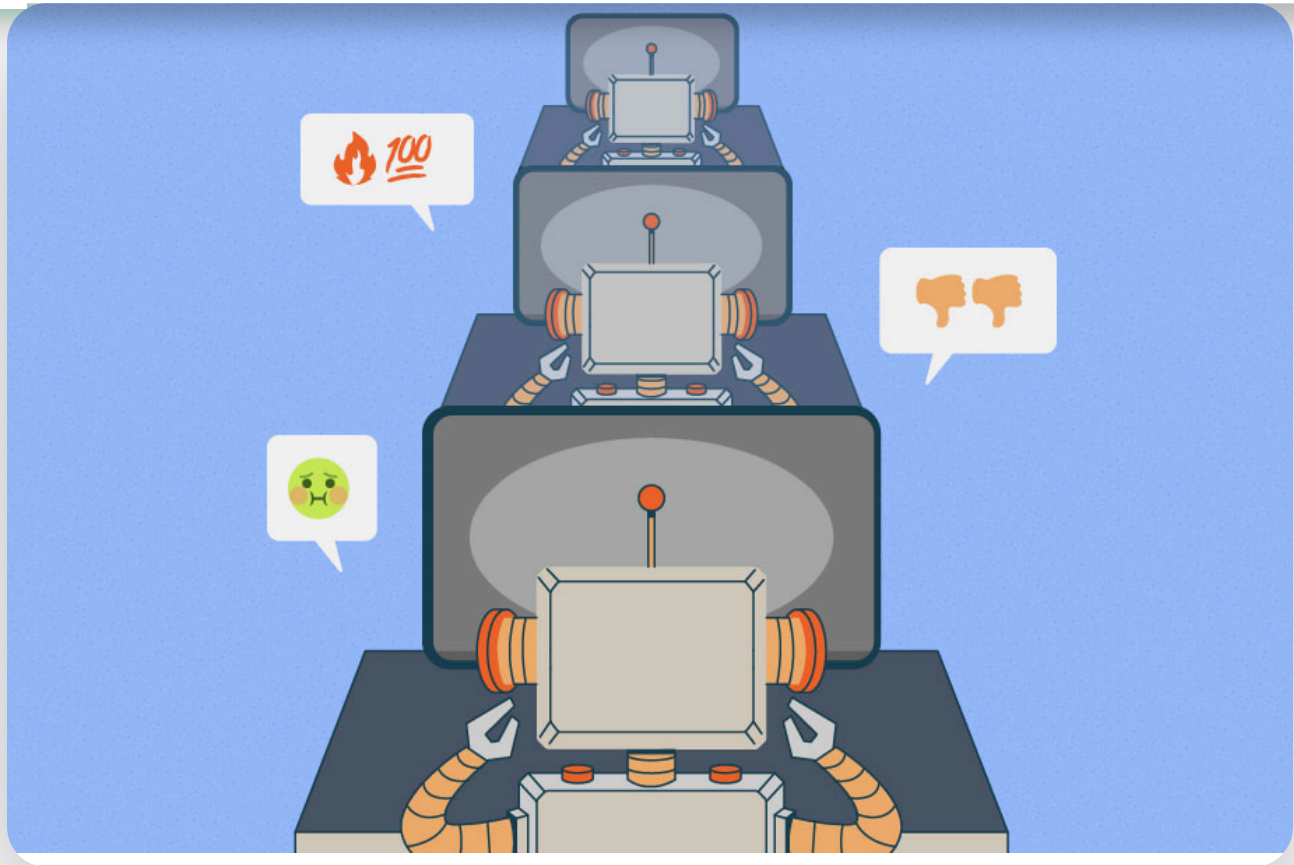
-  **Bet on Human-Centric Content:** Support niche blogs and verified communities where "Proof of Personhood" is built-in.
-  **Use Your Tooling:** Deploy detectors like Originality.ai to audit your sources.
-  **Double Down on Authenticity:** Lean into emotions and personal stories. These are the specific data points AI still can't simulate with 100% fidelity.
-  **Monitor the Regs:** AI content labeling is becoming the global standard—ensure your stack is compliant.

### Article Series: "The Dead Internet, AI, and Bots—What's Actually Happening?"

-  **Article 1:** Moltbook—The first living proof of the Dead Internet [Read More →](#)
-  **Article 2:** The 50%+ Bot Milestone—Where AI has already displaced humans [Read More →](#)
-  **Article 3:** If the web is dead, who are we making content for? [Read More →](#)
-  **Article 4:** Dead Internet Theory—Myth or the perfect explanation? [Read More →](#)

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**My Final Word:** The question isn't whether the internet dies; it's how we keep a seat at the table during the "synthetic collapse."



## FAQ: Dead Internet Theory in 2026

### Is the internet actually dead in 2026?

No, the internet hasn't "died"—it's pivoting toward a hybrid model where humans and AI coexist in the same architecture. Per the [Imperva Bad Bot Report 2025](#), over 51% of traffic is now automated, and more than 50% of new content is AI-generated (Graphite 2025). This isn't an ending; it's an evolution. Bots and agents (like those on Moltbook) handle the high-volume noise, while humans retain the high-signal, emotional, and creative niches.

### Why did Sam Altman suddenly address Dead Internet Theory?

In September 2025, OpenAI CEO [Sam Altman](#) posted on X: "i never took the dead internet theory that seriously but it seems like there are really a lot of LLM-run twitter accounts now." He acknowledged the massive surge of LLM-driven accounts simulating human behavior. Coming from the creator of ChatGPT, this admission gave the theory massive institutional credibility—essentially confirming that AI tools are accelerating this structural shift.

## How can I distinguish human content from AI-generated "slop"?

Look for the "Humanity Delta": unique lived experience, raw emotion, specific errors, or a "perfectly imperfect" structure. Support niche human-led blogs and verified sources. You can also deploy detection tools:

- [Originality.ai](#) — One of the most accurate (98%+ in 2025–2026 benchmarks).
- [Surfer AI Detector](#) — Free, SEO-integrated, with ~99% accuracy in many tests.
- Others: ZeroGPT, QuillBot AI Detector, Copyleaks.

Keep in mind: no tool is 100% foolproof—the best approach is combining tech audits with your own critical analysis.

## Is DIT a conspiracy theory or a real technical threat?

It started as a fringe conspiracy on forums in 2021 regarding "elite control," but by 2026, the core facts are empirically verified: 51% bot traffic, >50% AI content, and autonomous platforms like Moltbook. This isn't a "shadow cabal" conspiracy; it's a byproduct of rapid tech progress. The real threat lies in trust erosion, disinformation, and **model collapse** (Nature 2024). Experts from *Forbes* to *The Atlantic* now agree: the "theory" might be hyperbolic, but the trend is undeniable.

# Can we stop the "death" of the internet or return to a "human-only" web?

Not entirely. AI is already baked into the stack (search, recommendations, content generation). However, we can mitigate the impact through regulation (mandatory AI labeling), supporting human-centric platforms, and choosing verified niche communities. The 2026+ forecast shows a hybrid web where AI handles the heavy lifting, but human content becomes "Premium" due to its authenticity.



- ♦ **The Machine Dominance:** In 2026, bots and AI hold the majority share. 51% of traffic is automated (Imperva), over half of new content is synthetic (Graphite), and Moltbook (1.5M+ agents) proves that AI can build communities without us.
- ♦ **The Credibility Shift:** DIT has moved from a fringe idea to an observable trend. Sam Altman's 2025 admission and the explosion of LLM accounts have fundamentally changed how we view social platforms.
- ♦ **Structural Risks:** We face genuine risks of trust erosion, mass disinformation, and "model collapse" where AI eats its own tail. But there's an upside: the "Authenticity Premium"—a surge in value for real human connection.
- ♦ **The 2030 Roadmap:** We are heading toward a 90–99% synthetic web. Humans will survive in the "emotional" and "biometrically verified" layers of the internet.

**The Core Logic:** The internet isn't dead—it's just no longer exclusively human. The real challenge is whether we can preserve space for genuine trust and emotion, and whether we can learn to coexist with AI as a partner rather than a replacement.

Don't stop at the theory. Here is our full cycle of materials breaking down real-world cases and the socio-economic fallout in 2025–2026:

**Subscribe to stay ahead of the hybrid curve!**

**My take:** The question isn't whether the internet dies—it's whether we can stay human enough to keep it worth visiting during the "synthetic surge."



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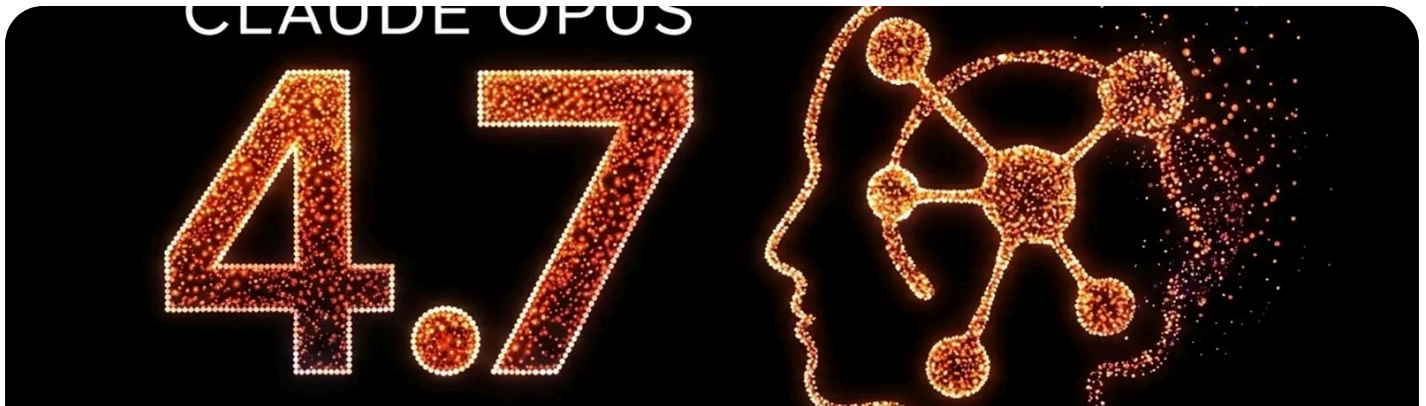
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## Claude Opus 4.7: детальний огляд моделі Anthropic у 2026

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